



Learn English with Friends

**Vocabulary, Slang, &
90s Culture from “The
One with Five Steaks
and an Eggplant”**

1. The Income Gap

Navigating the awkward reality of friends who make money versus friends who don't.

2. The Analog Catfish

Using 90s landlines and answering machines to steal a fake identity.

3. The Workplace Disaster

When a career-making promotion turns into a corporate policy violation.



To split the check
(verb phrase)

To divide a restaurant bill equally among everyone at the table, regardless of what individuals actually ordered. In the episode, Ross suggests splitting a massive bill six ways, sparking a major fight.

Steep
(adjective)

Very expensive or unreasonably high.

"Look guys, I know \$62 for a birthday gift is a little steep..."

The High Earners

(Ross, Chandler, Monica)

The Broke Friends

(Rachel, Phoebe, Joey)

1

Cajun Catfish, Carpaccio,
Grilled Prawns

Side salad (next to water),
Cucumber soup, Teeny pizza

2

"I just never think of
money as an issue."

"How much do you think I
can get for my kidney?"

Cha-ching (slang) - An exclamation mimicking the sound of a cash register; used to describe something very expensive.

"Wow, look at these prices. Yeah, these are pretty cha-ching."

The Intention

"It's our treat."
(Generosity)



The Reality

"Your nice thing makes
us feel this big."
(Humiliation)



The Result

Charity (noun) - Giving help
or money to those in need,
which feels deeply insulting
when given to equals.



Tonedeaf (adjective) - Unable to
understand the sensitivities of
others. Example: Chandler telling
his broke friends that feeling poor
is "just how you feel," right after
ordering an expensive fish dinner.

Screening calls *(verb phrase)*

Listening to a voicemail aloud as it is being recorded to decide whether or not to pick up the phone.

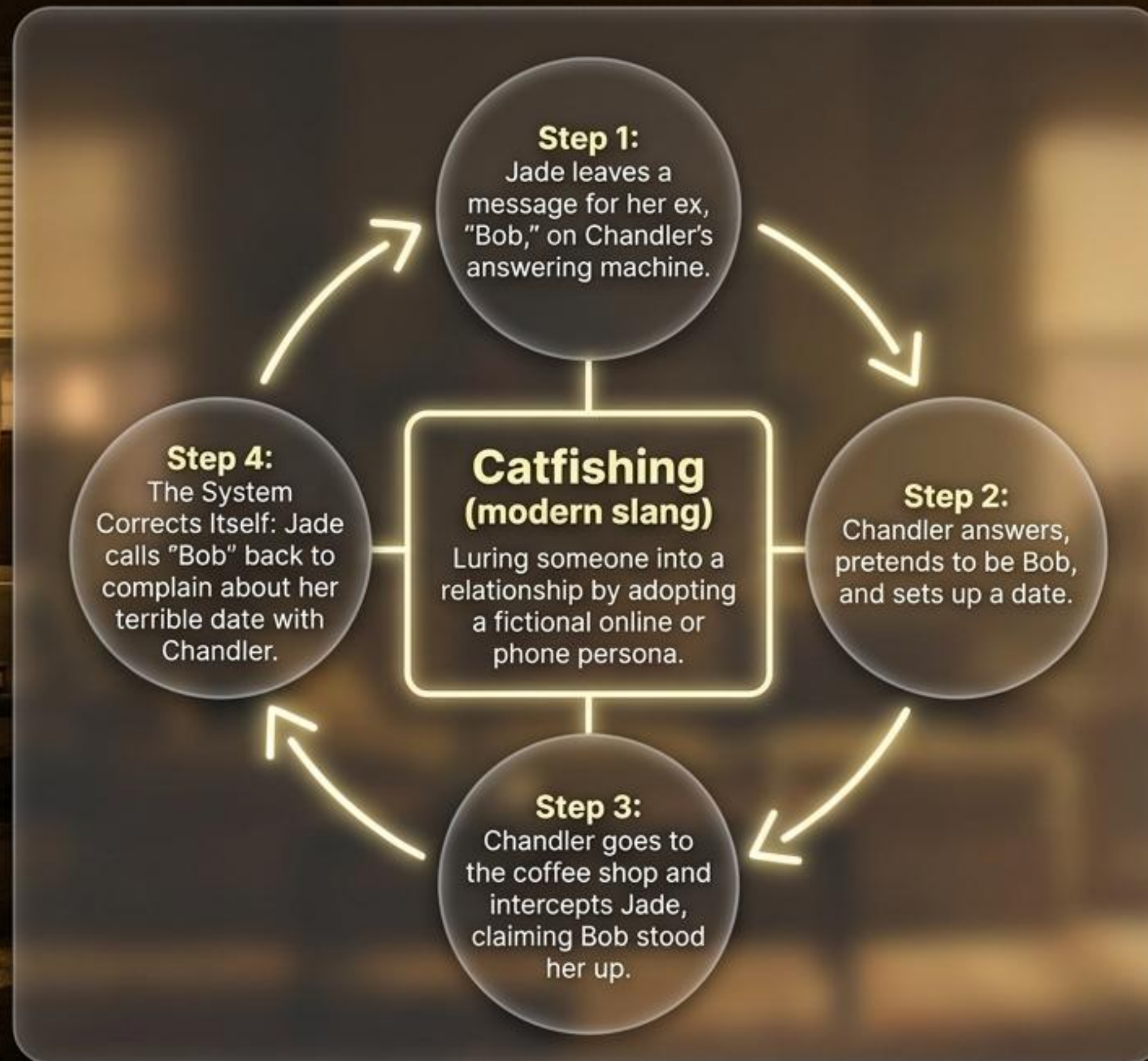
"I'm trying this new screening thing. I figure if I'm always answering the phone, people'll think I don't have a life."

Landline *(noun)*

A traditional phone connected by a physical wire, shared by an entire household.

If someone calls the wrong number, whoever answers controls the narrative.





Hook up (*verb*) -

To spend time with or be intimate with someone.

Fling (*noun*) -

A short, casual sexual relationship.

Bumpy (*adjective*) -

Rough, uneven, or awkward.

The Feedback: Jade calls "Bob" to complain that her hookup with Chandler was "mediocre," "over too fast," and completely "awkward and bumpy."

Beeper / Pager (*noun*)

A 90s wireless telecommunications device that receives text or voice messages.

A status symbol for on-the-go professionals.

Promotion (*noun*)

Being advanced to a higher position or rank. Monica is promoted to Head Lunch Chef and Head of Purchasing.





The Anatomy of a Kickback

The Event

Monica changes meat suppliers for the restaurant.

The Gift

The new supplier gives Monica 5 expensive steaks as a "thank you."

The Reality

Kickback (*noun*)
An illicit payment or gift made to someone in return for facilitating a business transaction.

The Consequence

Corporate Policy Violation.
Monica is fired on the spot over the phone.

The Conflict Ends

To evaporate (verb)

To disappear suddenly and completely.

“When Monica lost her job, the money argument evaporated. Nobody cares about splitting checks when a friend is hurting.”

The Night Ends

A bust (noun)

A complete failure or waste of time.

“Aside from the hickey, the whole evening was pretty much a bust.”

The Slang: Hoopla

(noun)

Excitement, fuss, or commotion surrounding an event.

"Whoa, I don't want my birthday to be the source of any negative hoopla."

The Culture Note

Hootie and the Blowfish were a massive mid-90s pop-rock band.

Getting free tickets and a backstage pass to meet the band in 1995 was the ultimate VIP treatment, which is why the broke friends felt the "charity" so deeply.



Split the check
Steep
Cha-ching



Promotion
Kickback

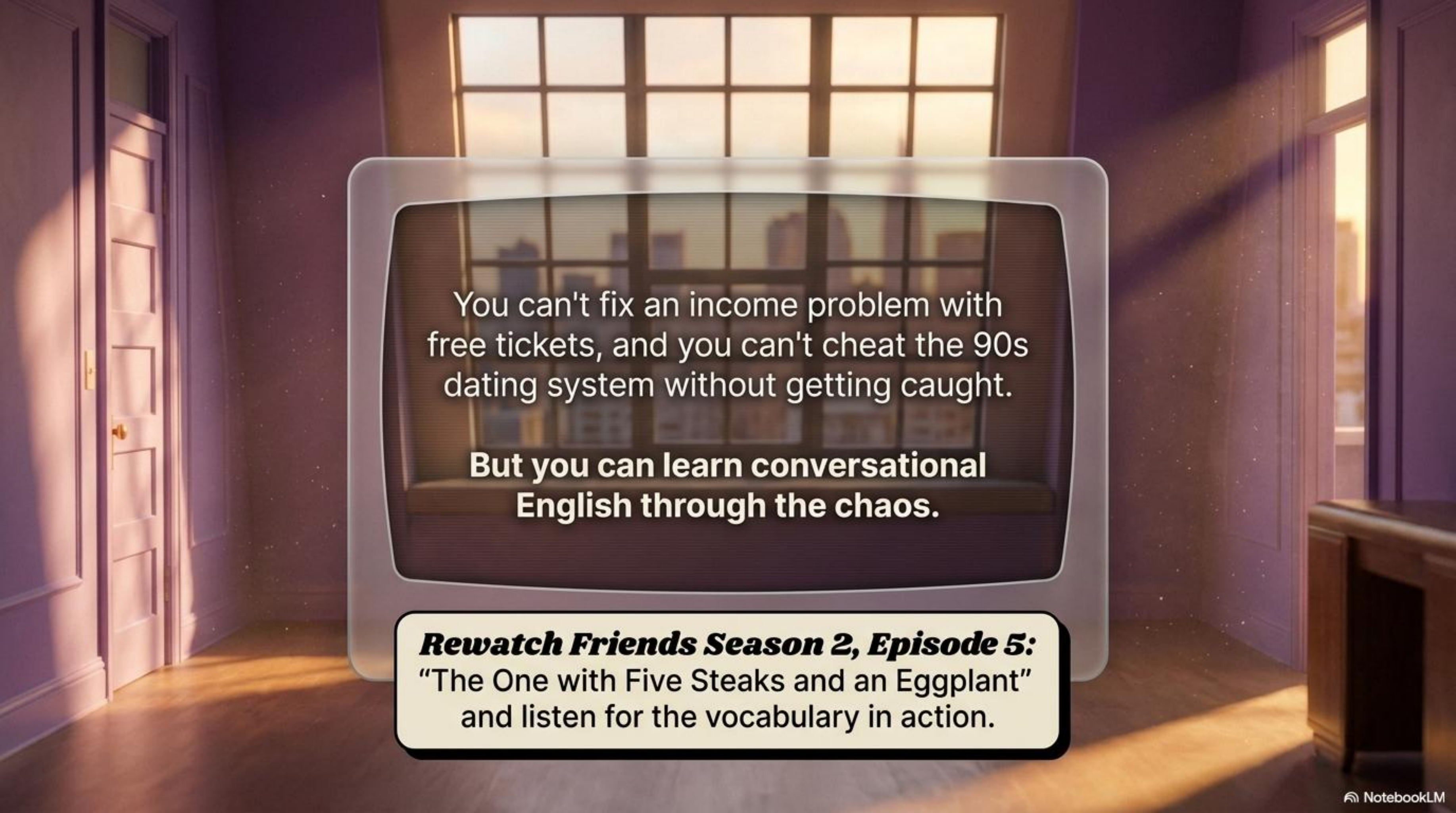


Screening
Catfishing
Bumpy



Charity
Tonedeaf
Hoopla



A virtual television set is positioned in the center of a room. The room has a large window with a grid pattern in the background, through which a cityscape is visible. To the left of the TV is a white door with a brass handle. To the right is a wooden desk. Sunlight streams in from the window, creating a warm, golden glow across the room. The TV screen displays the following text:

You can't fix an income problem with free tickets, and you can't cheat the 90s dating system without getting caught.

But you can learn conversational English through the chaos.

Rewatch Friends Season 2, Episode 5:

"The One with Five Steaks and an Eggplant"
and listen for the vocabulary in action.